STUDY SHEET · SOCIOLOGY

Populism & deliberation

Müller's definition of populism, the three meanings of "the people", and Dryzek's answer to the crisis of democracy.

— Tipoki

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Müller, What Is Populism? · Dryzek et al., "The crisis of democracy and the science of deliberation" (Science, 2019)

> *Two readings, one puzzle. Müller asks **what populism really is**, and why it is more than harsh criticism of elites. Dryzek and colleagues ask **what democracy can do about it**: their answer is that the crisis is one of communication, not of individual reasoning.*

01 Müller: what populism is

A moralized form of antipluralism.

For **Jan-Werner Müller**, populism is "a particular moralistic imagination of politics": a way of seeing the political world that sets a **morally pure and fully unified, but ultimately fictional, people** against elites who are corrupt or morally inferior.

MÜLLER'S TEST

$$Populism = anti\text{-}elitism + antipluralism$$

Anti-elitism is necessary but **not sufficient**: otherwise anyone who criticises the powerful would be a populist.

Antipluralism	Populists claim that **they, and only they, represent the people**. Out of power, rivals are the corrupt elite; in government, populists recognise no legitimate opposition.
Pars pro toto	"A part for the whole": a part of the citizens claims to be the people, in a **moral**, not empirical, sense.
Holism	A notion borrowed from **Nancy Rosenblum**: the polity should no longer be split, and the people can have one true representative. (Not the sociological "holism".)
Claude Lefort	The "real people" must be **"extracted"** from the sum total of actual citizens.

Populism "arises with the introduction of representative democracy; it is its shadow". Whoever does not support the populists may not be part of "the proper people to begin with".

Why a theory and not a history? Following **Nietzsche** ("only that which has no history can be defined"), Müller refuses to root the concept in one historical experience: we need a theory of the "-ism" to decide which experiences fit, just as socialism does not include National Socialism because the Nazis used the word.

KEY TAKEAWAYS

- Populism is **not** always nationalism, and criticising elites is not enough.
- Not every antipluralist is a populist: Leninists or intolerant religious actors do not see the people as morally pure and unerring in its will.

02 “The people” in three senses

Not every appeal to the people is populist.

Sense	Meaning
The whole	All members of the polity: the **body politic**.
The common people	The commoners; today the excluded, the downtrodden and the forgotten.
The nation	The people as a whole, understood in a distinctly **cultural** sense.

Fighting for the common people, or even idealising them (the Russian **narodniki**), is not enough. In Rome, fighting for the plebs is not populism; claiming that *only* the plebs are the *populus Romanus*, and that only certain populares represent them, is. The same goes for the **popolo** against the **grandi** in Machiavelli’s Florence.

CLAIMS OF EXCLUSIVE REPRESENTATION

Figure	Claim
George Wallace	“Segregation forever”, in the name of “the greatest people that have ever trod this earth”; the real America is the Southern mind.
Nigel Farage	Brexit is a “victory for real people”, making the 48% who voted Remain somehow less than real.
Donald Trump	“The other people don’t mean anything”, a remark that went virtually unnoticed.
Mikhail Bakunin	The people as “the only source of moral truth”: idealisation, not necessarily populism.

03 Work, ethnicity and the excluded

Who is outside the “real people”?

Populists often define the real people through **work and corruption**. **Producerism** pits the hardworking people against those who do not really work: the elite above, and the marginal groups at the bottom, said to live as parasites. Right-wing populism sees a symbiosis between an elite that does not truly belong and marginal groups that are also distinct from the people.

Andrew Jackson	His followers opposed “aristocrats” above and Native Americans and slaves below.
Silvio Berlusconi	Cast “Communists” and illegal immigrants as outside the people in Italy.
Birthers	Obsessed with proving Obama was an illegal, “un-American” office holder: both the elite that does not belong and the marginal Other.
Jobbik	Hungarian far-right party that analogises “politician crime” and “gypsy crime”.

When “work” proves indeterminate, **ethnic markers** can come to the rescue: racist thought equates race and laziness without saying so. Yet it is a mistake to think populism always ends up as nationalism or ethnic chauvinism: what must be present is some distinction between the morally pure people and their opponents.

04 Dryzek et al.: the crisis of democracy

A crisis of communication, not of individual reasoning.

The article by **John S. Dryzek** and 19 co-authors (Science, 15 March 2019) lists the symptoms: information overload that overwhelms policy-makers and citizens, uncivil elites and pathological mass communication that reinforce each other, declining trust, and a growing mismatch between simple solutions and complex problems.

Post-truth politics	Facts and evidence displaced by the "felt truth" of **cultural cognition**, where social identity conditions opinion.
Epistocracy	Government by wise elites, an argument fuelled by survey research that doubts citizen competence.
Monological research	Survey research only observes the individual **reasoning in isolation**.
Echo chambers	Spaces that intensify cultural cognition, identity reaffirmation and polarisation.

The authors' reply: "even if people are bad solitary reasoners, they can be good group problem-solvers." The remedy has to involve ordinary citizens; fact-checking alone is futile while the public is ripe to be polarised.

KEY TAKEAWAYS

- Diagnosis: a **crisis of communication**. Individual reasoning is much as it always was.
- Citizens listen less to content and follow partisan cues more, or drop out.

05 What deliberation research finds

Democracy built on listening and mutual justification.

Deliberative democracy involves inclusive participation of citizens and leaders, mutual justification, listening, respect, reflection and openness to persuasion. **Aristotle** grounded practical reason in collective political life. What is new is the precision with which deliberation's tasks (legitimation, mutual understanding, integrating diverse knowledge) have been specified and tested.

Example	What it shows
Irish constitutional convention	Majority of lay citizens, minority of politicians, on same-sex marriage and abortion.
Europolis	Transnational, multilingual: classical deliberative standards are not utopian.
Gram sabhas (India)	State-mandated village assemblies: arguably the world's biggest deliberative institution.
Mongolia	A deliberative poll with several hundred ordinary citizens.
Participedia	Online catalogue of deliberative experiments worldwide.

Findings: people do want to take part once meaningful deliberation is on offer, and those most willing to deliberate are precisely those turned off by standard partisan politics. Good processes provide balanced information, expert testimony and a facilitator.

06 Making deliberation work

From small forums to a whole system.

Deliberative system	Many linked places for deliberation: executives, legislatures, citizen forums, media, informal gatherings.
Citizens' Initiative Review	Oregon: a random panel of citizens deliberates a referendum question and publicises the pros and cons.
Stuttgart 21	A station project whose conflict made citizen deliberation compulsory for large infrastructure in Baden-Württemberg.
#Ichbinhier	European movement applying evidence-based argument and civility online.

PUTTING THE TWO READINGS TOGETHER

- Müller: populism denies pluralism by saying only **part** of the people is the people.
- Dryzek: deliberation rebuilds the **conversation among all citizens**, which is exactly what antipluralism rejects.
- Be ready to give an example from each: Wallace or Farage for populism, the Irish convention or Oregon's CIR for deliberation.

Tipoki · *Read it through once, then play a round to lock it in.*